Lesson 05: Verb Basics in Academic Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 9 Verb Basics in Academic Writing.

In this lesson

You will review the basic types of English verbs: "Be" and "Do" verbs, action and non-action verbs, helping and main verbs. You will also meet the twelve verb tenses and the five basic verb forms. Every English sentence needs a verb, and verb errors cause serious misunderstanding, so these basics prepare you for the tense lessons later in the course.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Find the verbs in a sentence and explain what a verb does.
- Tell "Be" verbs from "Do" verbs, and never use a "Be" verb before the base form of a "Do" verb.
- Tell action verbs from non-action verbs, and keep non-action verbs out of progressive tenses.
- Identify helping verbs (including modals) and main verbs.
- Name the twelve verb tenses and the five basic verb forms.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
verb	a word that expresses an action or shows a state of existence	Dogs bark. Pets are our good friends.
"Be" verb	am, is, are, was, were and the other forms of "be"	Her name is Bonny.
"Do" verb	any other verb: study, get, sleep, wear, have, like, think...	Bonny stays indoors most days.
action verb	a verb that shows the action of the subject	Some of them sleep in their owner's bed.
non-action verb	a verb that shows a state: feelings, thoughts, the senses, possession; also called a stative or non-progressive verb	Pets love their owners.
helping verb	a verb that works with the main verb to show tense, make a negative or a question, or change meaning; also called an auxiliary verb	He does not want to carpool.
main verb	the verb that carries the main meaning	He has prepared for this test.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
modal	a special helping verb for ability, possibility, obligation, advice and more	Every driver must have a driver's license.
base form	the simple form of a verb, as in a dictionary	study, move, speak
present participle / past participle	the -ing form / the form used after have, has, had	studying / studied, spoken
ex·IS·tence	being there, being this way	A verb shows a state of existence.
con·TENT (adjective)	happy and satisfied	He looks content in his sleep.

Rules and explanations

What is a verb?

Each English sentence must have a verb. A verb expresses an action or shows a state of existence. In most sentences it follows the subject (the person or thing the sentence is about): *Most pets are lovely*. A subject and its verb must match, and so must a tense and its verb form. A **compound verb** is two or more verbs for the same subject: *They keep their owners company and make them happy*.

"Be" verbs and "Do" verbs

A "Be" verb (am, is, are, was, were) is often followed by:

- a noun: *My neighbor's pet is a rabbit.*
- a pronoun: *Bonny is not mine.*
- an adjective: *Bonny's tail is short and cute.*
- a prepositional phrase (a phrase that starts with a preposition such as in or at): *Bonny is in a cage when my neighbor is at work.*
- an age: *Bonny was two months old when I first met her.*

All other verbs are "Do" verbs: study, get, sleep, wear, have, like, think... Their forms change with the subject and the tense: *Bonny stays indoors most days. I played with her yesterday.*

A "Be" verb is NEVER followed by the base form of a "Do" verb.

- Wrong: Bonny is stay indoors most days. Correct: Bonny stays indoors most days.
- Wrong: Most rabbits are stay in a cage. Correct: Most rabbits stay in a cage.
- Wrong: I was meet my neighbor's pet rabbit for the first time last week. Correct: I met my neighbor's pet rabbit for the first time last week.

Action and non-action verbs

Action verbs show the action of the subject; all action verbs are "Do" verbs: *Many pet owners treat their pets as part of the family. Those pets get special food.* **Non-action verbs** show states, not actions. "Be" verbs are non-action verbs in most cases. | Type | Common non-action verbs | |---|---| |

Emotional or mental state | appreciate, believe, detest, dislike, fear, forget, hate, imagine, know, like, love, mean, mind, miss, need, prefer, remember, respect, understand, want | | Five senses | appear, feel, hear, look, see, seem, smell, taste | | Possession | belong, contain, have, own, possess | | Others | cost, find |

Rule: non-action verbs can be used in all tenses except progressive tenses (be + -ing, for an action in progress); action verbs can be used in all tenses.

- He looks (NOT is looking) content in his sleep.
- Samantha likes (NOT is liking) kittens. She has (NOT is having) two. Right now she is preparing their favorite snacks.

Some verbs can be both, with different meanings: | Verb | Non-action | Action | |---|---|---| | think | What do you think of my kitten? (opinion) | She is always thinking about playing hide and seek. | | feel | It feels so soft. | Feel the fur of my kitten. | | measure | My kitten measures twelve inches in length. | I measure her every month. | | see | I see some red spots on the kitten's skin. (The book prints "pots".) | We are seeing the vet at 3 pm. (meeting) |

Helping verbs and main verbs

helping verb + main verb = complete verb. Helping verbs help the main verb to show the tense, make a negative, ask a question, change the meaning or tone, or change the voice (active or passive). Common helping verbs: do, does, did, have, has, had, will. Forms of "be" are also helping verbs in progressive tenses (is preparing, was waiting).

- Mohamod **has** always **wanted** to get his driver's license.
- He **does** not **want** to carpool with his friend every day.
- He hopes that he **will pass** the road test.
- **Should** he **celebrate** if he passes?

Modals (can, could, should, must…) are special helping verbs. They show ability, possibility, obligation, advice and more, and they are followed by the base form: *Maintaining a car can be expensive.*

Twelve verb tenses

A tense shows the time of an action or state (past, present, future, or from past to present) and whether it happened once, repeatedly, or is still happening: | | Past | Present | Future | |---|---|---|---| | Simple | He studied. | He studies. | He will study. / He is going to study. | | Progressive | He was studying. | He is studying. | He will be studying. / He is going to be studying. | | Perfect | He had studied. | He has studied. | He will have studied. | | Perfect progressive | He had been studying. | He has been studying. | He will have been studying. |

This course focuses on eight of them: simple present, present progressive, present perfect, present perfect progressive, simple past, past progressive, past perfect, and simple future.

Five basic verb forms

Base	Present	Present participle	Past	Past participle
be	am, is, are	being	was, were	been
do	do, does	doing	did	done
have	have, has	having	had	had
study	study, studies	studying	studied	studied
speak	speak, speaks	speaking	spoke	spoken

A verb tense and its verb forms must always match: has + studied, is + studying, will + study.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no present-tense "be" ("the tail short"), so check that every sentence has a verb: "Bonny's tail **is** short and cute." - Arabic makes negatives and questions without a helping verb like "do", so check for do/does/did: "He not want to carpool" → "He **does** not want to carpool."

Practice

Exercise 1. Find the verbs. The first one is an example. Dogs **are** popular pets. Dogs bark. Dogs run, bark, and protect their owners. Some dogs are friendly, and some are ferocious. Most dogs remain loyal to their owners. Most owners walk their dogs twice a day and feed them multiple times. To some people, it sounds like a lot of work! (The book prints "royal"; it means "loyal".)

Exercise 2. Is each verb in bold an action verb or a non-action verb? The first one is an example.

1. Dogs are color blind. It **means** that they cannot see certain colors or their differences. (non-action)
2. This does not **say** that there are no colors in a dog's world.
3. It **means** that some colors may **look** different to a dog.
4. For example, the red or green color **appears** grayish when a dog **looks** at it.
5. However, yellow **is** still yellow to a dog.
6. Some people **think** that the color yellow is most dogs' favorite.
7. These dogs may be very excited about a yellow ball, but they do not **show** excitement to a red ball.
8. Owners should **choose** their pet dog's favorite color.

Exercise 3. Write the helping verb in each sentence. The first one is an example. (The book has no item 3.)

1. Does Jose have a car? (Does)
2. Yes, but he does not use it every day.

4. Jose has had his car for two years.
5. He had relied on public transportation before he bought the car.
6. He could not go to many places at that time.

7. Now his car has provided him much convenience.
8. Jose will be happy to give you a ride.
9. According to him, friends should always help each other.
10. Understandably, he does not let anyone drive his car!

Exercise 5. A story about two puppies in love. Choose the type of the verb(s) in bold.

1. A long time ago, a dog named Shiro **received** a nickname "a Puppy in Love". The story **happened** on a small Japanese island Aka in the 1980s. ("Do" verbs / "Be" verbs)
2. Shiro **belonged** to Mr. and Mrs. Nakamura. (action / non-action)
3. He **was** always wet when he returned. Mr. and Mrs. Nakamura **were** surprised and curious. ("Be" verbs / "Do" verbs)
4. Mr. Nakamura said, "I **will** find out." (helping / main)
5. When Shiro **started** to swim, Mr. Nakamura **jumped** onto his little fishing boat and **followed** him. (non-action / action)
6. Three hours later, Shiro **got** onto an island called Zamami and **walked** to a house. (main / helping)
7. Another puppy was waiting for him. She **did** not leave until she saw him! (helping / main)
8. The two puppies **had** become good friends then. (helping / main)
9. After the Nakamuras moved, Shiro frequently **visited** his girlfriend puppy. In the evening, he **swam** back home to Aka. (action / non-action)
10. When the public **heard** about the story, many people came to Aka and Zamami to **see** Shiro and his girlfriend puppy. (action / non-action)
11. They wondered how long Shiro had to swim. They **were** very curious. ("Be" / "Do")
12. The ocean between the two islands **was** more than two miles long, and people **were** amazed to see the puppies in love! ("Do" verbs / "Be" verbs)

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me to explain the difference between 'I think' and 'I am thinking', 'It feels' and 'I feel', and 'I see' and 'I am seeing'. Correct me."
- "Give me ten sentences about my psychology course. Some use a non-action verb in a progressive tense or 'be' + base form. I will find and correct the errors."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. I underlined the 'Be' verbs, put the helping verbs in capitals and marked the non-action verbs with a star. Check my marking."

Read aloud

Past forms with -ed have three endings: /ɪd/ after a t or d sound, /t/ after other voiceless sounds (such as p, k, s), and /d/ after voiced sounds.

1. Mohamod has always wanted /ɪd/ to get his driver's license.

2. Shiro belonged /d/ to Mr. and Mrs. Nakamura.
3. When Shiro started /ɪd/ to swim, Mr. Nakamura jumped /t/ onto his little fishing boat and followed /d/ him.
4. Three hours later, Shiro got onto an island called /d/ Zamami and walked /t/ to a house.
5. After the Nakamuras moved /d/, Shiro frequently visited /ɪd/ his girlfriend puppy.

Writing task

NSNT practice and verb check (the book's NSNT Practice and Exercise 6). Choose two topics from the weekly prompts in Appendix A (for example: What are your hobbies? Describe them.). For each, write nonstop for three to five minutes without translating, then rewrite it as a paragraph of about 150 words. Be mindful of your verbs: main or helping? Action or non-action? "Be" or "Do"? Then mark them: underline the "Be" verbs, write the helping verbs in capitals, and put a star after the non-action verbs.

Self-editing checklist

- Does every sentence have a subject and a verb?
- Is any "Be" verb followed by the base form of a "Do" verb ("is stay")? Fix it.
- Is any non-action verb (know, like, have, want…) in a progressive tense? Change it.
- Does every helping verb have a main verb, in the right form (has + past participle, will + base form, is + -ing)?
- Do negatives and questions have do, does or did where needed?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book) are (example), bark, run, bark, protect, are, are, remain, walk, feed, sounds

Exercise 2 (book)

1. non-action (example) 2. action 3. means: non-action; look: non-action 4. appears: non-action; looks: action 5. non-action 6. non-action 7. action 8. action

Exercise 3 (book)

1. Does (example) 2. does 4. has 5. had 6. could 7. has 8. will 9. should 10. does

Exercise 5 (book)

1. "Do" verbs 2. non-action (possession) 3. "Be" verbs 4. helping 5. action 6. main 7. helping 8. helping 9. action 10. non-action (verbs of the senses) 11. "Be" 12. "Be" verbs

My notes